

Self-Gravity with Mesh Refinement in the AthenaK Shearing Box

Program Summary: Phases 0–2c and First Gravitational Collapse

athenak-multigrid tree, branch multigrid

August 17, 2026

Goal and route

Target science: shearing-box simulations of gas + dust with self-gravity and AMR zoom-in on gravitationally induced dust clumps (streaming-instability / GI-arm interaction, cf. Baehr, Zhu & Yang 2022), and the Gammie (2001) gravitoturbulence program. Chosen route: a **multigrid Poisson solver with shear-periodic boundary conditions on refined meshes**, with a uniform-grid **FFT solver as the machine-precision oracle** throughout. All work is validated against analytic solutions, the FFT oracle, and the published Athena++ results the solver descends from (Tomida & Stone 2023). Full details: `multigrid_selfgravity_validation.pdf` (32 pp.), reproduced end-to-end by `multigrid_validation_tests.ipynb` (44 code cells); the FFT track has its own companion document.

Phase 0 — shearing box + mesh refinement infrastructure (hydro)

- **Orbital-advection toggle:** a fully consistent non-FARGO mode (measured cost 5.7×: CFL against the full shear flow), enabling A/B tests and future patch refinement.
- **Refinement policies:** interior- x_1 / uniform-boundary-level rule (both shear faces share one level), and the *annular* policy under FARGO — refined regions span complete azimuthal rings, so the per-level y -shift only ever involves same-size neighbors.
- **AMR:** shear-boundary communication state rebuilt after every remesh; a graded-refinement cap keeps 2:1 balancing off the boundary columns; an upstream derefinement-ordering bug (partial ring splits) found and fixed.
- **Validation:** ring SMR bit-identical to reference runs; 20-orbit epicycle endurance — amplitude drift 0.008% (ring+FARGO) vs. 0.064% (uniform); AMR with a prescribed moving ring: 2296 blocks created / 2240 destroyed over 20 orbits, mass conserved exactly, matches the static ring an order of magnitude closer than either matches the uniform grid.

Phase 1 — shear-periodic multigrid boundary conditions (uniform)

Shear-periodicity enters as a boundary *identification* only: a y -remapped x_1 ghost fill (conservative PPMX remap) applied at every level of the multigrid hierarchy through global boundary planes; the 7-point operator is untouched. Key results: solves at shear-periodic instants are **bit-identical** to plain-periodic solves; the analytic shearing-wave potential is recovered *below* the FFT solver’s own error (9.5×10^{-8} vs. 1.6×10^{-6} at 128^3); the swing-amplification history matches FFT to 2×10^{-7} ;

V-cycle contraction degrades only $0.116 \rightarrow 0.157$ under a near-worst shear phase. Anchored to Tomida & Stone (2023): their §4.1 convergence factor (0.125), second-order accuracy (identical to FFT to all digits), and §4.3 Jeans-wave results all reproduce.

Phase 2 — multigrid gravity on refined shearing-box meshes

phase	configuration	headline validation
2a	static interior rings (boundary blocks at root)	guard-only change; ring solves bit-identical to periodic twins at $q_{\text{omt}} = 0$; L_2 2nd order; swing peak shifts <i>toward</i> theory, gravity-off control dominates $\Rightarrow$ solver adds no error
2b	boundary annuli (refined blocks <i>on</i> the shear faces)	sheared octet ghost fill (host-side, rank-replicated, no MPI seam); bit-identity at 1 and 2 levels; contraction unchanged (0.18–0.20)
2c	AMR	shear planes/offsets/octet flags rebuilt per remesh; moving-ring swing: several hundred remeshes, no solver warnings; $\text{np}=2 \equiv$ serial to every printed digit

The octet (refinement) machinery inherited with AthenaK #776 was first anchored on the isolated binary-potential test (T&S §4.2): region-wise second order against the analytic two-sphere solution. Throughout Phase 2 the refinement interface — not the shear — owns the error budget, and every dynamic test carries a gravity-off control proving the gravity solver contributes nothing beyond hydro truncation. One practical finding: refined meshes should run FMG with a *fixed* V-cycle count (T&S practice); the stagnation-exit stopping rule can hit its iteration cap mid-run on wound-up shear modes.

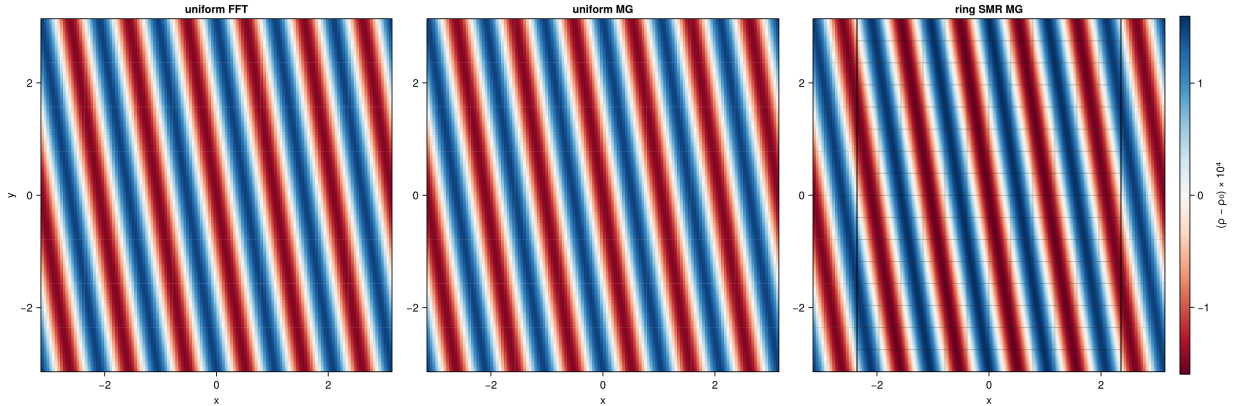


Figure 1: The Phase-2a swing test: final density for uniform FFT, uniform multigrid, and ring-SMR multigrid — the two uniform panels agree at the float32 quantization floor, and the wave crosses every refinement boundary without artifact.

Into the unstable regime: first collapse (this week)

With the machinery validated, the swing test was pushed past the box-scale Jeans threshold ($4\pi G > \kappa^2 + k^2 c_s^2 = 2$). An empirical ladder established what clumping actually requires: transient

waves *bounce* unless the compressed crest itself becomes Jeans-unstable during the unstable window ($\lambda_J(\rho_{\text{crest}})$ below the crest width). At $4\pi G = 6$, $\text{amp} = 0.2$ the crest fragments at $t \approx 4.5$ and collapses into a **bound clump** at $\rho = 203\rho_0$ — beyond the uniform-grid Truelove ceiling ($171\rho_0$), motivating the AMR zoom, which follows the crest and clump with density-triggered rings (the annular policy answers “how do you zoom under FARGO”: rings, completed automatically by the flag-sync, not local patches). The multigrid solver ran the entire collapse — a 200:1 density contrast on a shear-periodic adaptive mesh — with zero convergence failures.

The program is now **deployed on NAS HECC**: a 256^2 discriminator run at 64 ranks confirmed the two-site fragmentation as physical (the 128^2 single clump was an under-resolution artifact), and its $t=14$ extension followed the winner-takes-all endpoint — runaway to $2.6 \times 10^5\rho_0$ with the companion consumed — with the solver machine-clean through the quarter-million contrast. The deployment also exposed (deterministically, at the same timestep in two attempts) a latent **upstream bug** in the shearing-box x_1 exchange: sender and receiver computed the integer shear shift from their own MeshBlocks’ stored cell sizes, whose last-ulp roundoff can disagree near integer crossings, desynchronizing MPI message sizes. All seven shift computations now derive from bitwise-identical global mesh quantities; the fix is validated from serial (bit-identical to prior references) to 64 ranks.

Finally, an **FFT-solver cross-check** closed the last audit channel: a serial FFT twin of the 256^2 collapse matches the multigrid run to 5×10^{-8} through the linear phase and reproduces the *same two fragments within a third of a cell* after five nonlinear dynamical times; extended to $t=14$, both solvers reach the same fate on the same clock ($\rho=100$ crossings within 0.05), diverging only *beyond* the Truelove ceiling (FFT saturates near it; multigrid runs away unresolved) — a solver-based demonstration that past-ceiling densities are resolution artifacts. The y -boundary fragmentation has now survived four independent audits: resolution, mesh topology, rank count, and solver identity.

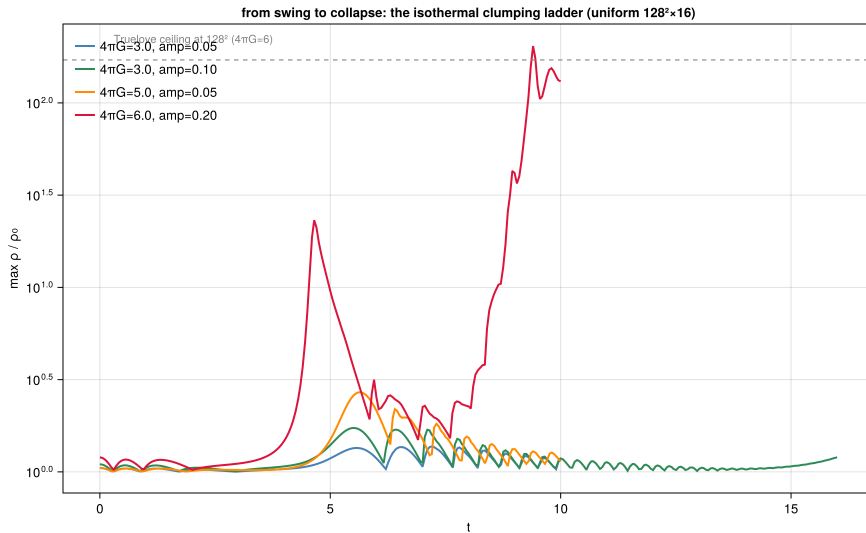


Figure 2: The nonlinear ladder: maximum density vs. time for the four uniform-grid runs, with the Truelove ceiling marked.

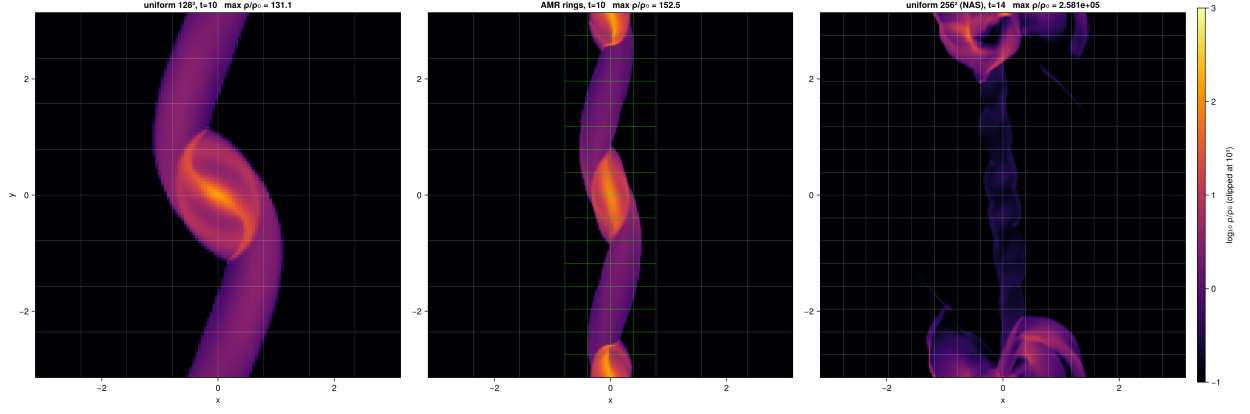


Figure 3: Final states of the collapse runs ($\log_{10} \rho$, MeshBlocks drawn, green = level 1): uniform 128^2 (fragments merged by under-resolution), the AMR run resolving both clumps, and the 256^2 NAS run at $t = 14$ in the winner-takes-all runaway.

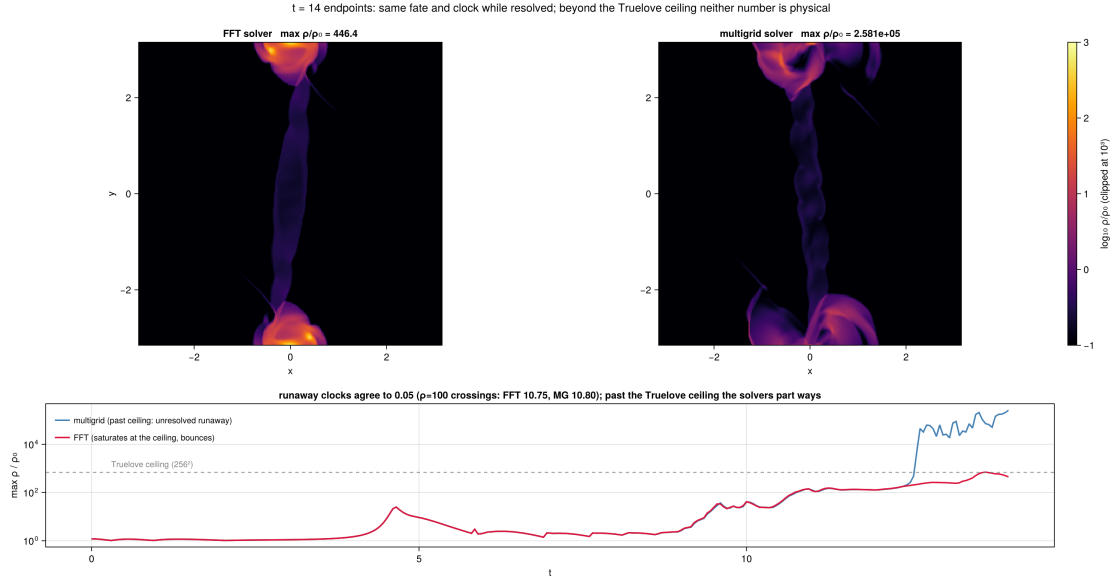


Figure 4: The solver cross-check at $t = 14$: FFT and multigrid agree on fate and clock while the collapse is resolved, and part ways only beyond the Truelove ceiling (dashed) — neither number is physical there.

Status and next steps

Delivered: FFT solver (validated, $3.5\times$ faster than multigrid on uniform grids, and now a full nonlinear cross-check twin); shearing-box refinement infrastructure incl. AMR; multigrid gravity on uniform, SMR-ring, boundary-annuli, and adaptive meshes, serial and MPI; ~ 30 pages of validation documentation, a 44-cell reproducing notebook, and versioned test inputs for every configuration. **Next:** (i) the Gammie (2001) gravitoturbulence program — β -cooling source term, Q and α diagnostics — using this stack as the production path; (ii) dust coupling (athenak-dust PM particles + IMEX drag) toward the SI+GI clumping science; (iii) deferred infrastructure: host-root shear fill, MHD face-centered remap with refinement, and (if deep zooms demand it) per-ring bookkeeping for patch refinement under FARGO.